

The last night.



THE NIGHT _____

Where _____

Whose place _____

Doors _____ Ends _____

How many _____

Dress _____

Music by _____

Budget _____

WHAT KIND OF NIGHT IS THIS _____ Decide it now

- ☐ A party
- ☐ Six people and a good dinner
- ☐ Out, then back here
- ☐ Children up till midnight
- ☐ Two of us and something better than usual
- ☐ Asleep by eleven, on purpose

MIDNIGHT ITSELF _____ Decide it in advance

The two things that ruin New Year’s Eve

Not enough to eat after eleven, and no way home. Everything else is decoration. Page 3 puts food on the table twice, and page 2 asks every guest how they are getting home **before** they arrive — because at one in the morning on the first of January there are no taxis, and there is no talking anyone out of driving.

BOOKED, ORDERED, PAID FOR _____

- ☐ _____
- ☐ _____
- ☐ _____
- ☐ _____

THE BITS THAT MAKE IT FEEL LIKE NEW YEAR

- ☐ Something fizzy, and something fizzy without alcohol
- ☐ Enough glasses out before eleven
- ☐ Whatever is on the television, found in advance
- ☐ A song for the first minute of the year
- ☐ A photograph, taken before everyone is tired

TOMORROW MORNING _____ Set it up tonight

Who is here, and how they leave.



ASK THE SECOND QUESTION TOO “How are you getting home?”

#	NAME	GETTING HOME HOW	INV	YES	NO	BED	BRINGING
01			☐	☐	☐	☐	
02			☐	☐	☐	☐	
03			☐	☐	☐	☐	
04			☐	☐	☐	☐	
05			☐	☐	☐	☐	
06			☐	☐	☐	☐	
07			☐	☐	☐	☐	
08			☐	☐	☐	☐	
09			☐	☐	☐	☐	
10			☐	☐	☐	☐	
11			☐	☐	☐	☐	
12			☐	☐	☐	☐	
13			☐	☐	☐	☐	
14			☐	☐	☐	☐	
15			☐	☐	☐	☐	
16			☐	☐	☐	☐	
17			☐	☐	☐	☐	
18			☐	☐	☐	☐	
19			☐	☐	☐	☐	
20			☐	☐	☐	☐	

INVITED COMING CAN'T STAYING DRIVING

Beds, sofas and a spare toothbrush

Tick the **Bed** column for anyone who might stay, and count them now rather than at midnight. Two people who planned to drive and changed their minds is the usual number. Blankets, a spare toothbrush and somewhere dark to sleep cost you nothing in advance and are impossible to produce at two in the morning.



00:00

HOUR BY HOUR

TIME

WHAT HAPPENS

WHO IS ON IT

NINE BEATS

Write the time next to each

1

Food out, the first time

Before anyone has had three drinks

2

Music up, lights down

The room changes or it does not

3

Glasses out, all of them

Counted, on a table, not in a cupboard

4

Bottles opened and poured

Ten minutes before, not on the hour

5

Everyone into one room

The hardest five minutes of the night

6

MIDNIGHT

Whatever you decided on page 1

7

Phone calls and messages

The network is busy; give it ten minutes

8

Food out, the second time

This is the one people remember

9

Taxis, coats, beds

Say it out loud once, kindly

Food twice, drink counted.



BEFORE ELEVEN ————— Grazing, not a sit-down

WHAT	WHO	GOT
_____	_____	☐
_____	_____	☐
_____	_____	☐
_____	_____	☐
_____	_____	☐
_____	_____	☐
_____	_____	☐
_____	_____	☐

AFTER MIDNIGHT ————— Hot, salty, and made in advance

_____	_____	☐
_____	_____	☐
_____	_____	☐
_____	_____	☐
_____	_____	☐
_____	_____	☐

The second round of food is the one people talk about the next day. It does not have to be clever — it has to exist, and it has to appear without anybody cooking at half past midnight.

HOW MANY BOTTLES ————— One 750 ml bottle is about six ...

PEOPLE	FOR THE TOAST	THE WHOLE EVENING
☐ 6 people	1 bottle	3 bottles
☐ 12 people	2 bottles	6 bottles
☐ 20 people	4 bottles	10 bottles
☐ 30 people	5 bottles	15 bottles

The evening column assumes about half a bottle of wine a head across the night. Round up. Nobody has ever regretted one bottle too many in the cupboard on the second of January.

NOT DRINKING ————— Count them properly; make it as good

☐

☐

☐

ICE, GLASSES, AND THE REST —————

- ☐ More ice than you believe
- ☐ Glasses counted, and a marker to name them
- ☐ A bottle opener that is not lost
- ☐ Bin bags out early, one for the glass

The year, in twelve lines.



ONE LINE EACH — The first thing you think of, not the best

January

February

March

April

May

June

July

August

September

October

November

December

Use a calendar, not your memory

Scroll back through your own photographs, or your diary, one month at a time. Almost nobody can remember March in December, and the year always turns out to have had more in it than it felt like. That is the point of the page.

BETTER THAN EXPECTED

HARDER THAN EXPECTED

PEOPLE WHO MATTERED THIS YEAR

SOMETHING YOU FINISHED — Even if nobody noticed

Not carrying this over.



The page most New Year planners are missing

A list of new things to start, on top of a year that is already full, is how January resolutions die by February. Before you add anything, take something off. Write down what you are putting down, and where it is written matters: a thing dropped on paper is dropped, a thing dropped in your head comes back.

OBLIGATIONS I AM NOT RENEWING

☐

☐

☐

☐

☐

THINGS THAT COST MONEY FOR NOTHING

WHATPER MONTHCANCELLED

		☐
		☐
		☐
		☐
		☐
		☐

A PROJECT I AM ALLOWED TO ABANDON

A HABIT THAT IS NOT WORKING

Name it plainly

SOMETHING I HAVE BEEN MEANING TO SAY

AND ONE THING I AM KEEPING, DELIBERATELY

Next year, on one page.



ONE TO START, ONE TO STOP, ONE TO FINISH —

START _____

STOP _____

FINISH _____

THE FOUR QUARTERS _____ A phrase each
WHEN _____ **WHAT IT IS FOR** _____ **IN A WORD** _____

Jan - Mar _____

Apr - Jun _____

Jul - Sep _____

Oct - Dec _____

ALREADY IN THE DIARY _____ Birthdays, trips, deadlines
WHAT _____ **WHEN** _____ **BOOKED** _____

_____	_____	☐
_____	_____	☐
_____	_____	☐
_____	_____	☐
_____	_____	☐
_____	_____	☐

MONEY, DECIDED IN JANUARY —

Saving towards _____

How much a month _____

Paying off _____

By when _____

One thing worth the money _____

SOMETHING TO LEARN, BADLY —

PEOPLE TO SEE MORE OF — Put a month next to each

_____	_____
_____	_____
_____	_____
_____	_____
_____	_____

IF THE YEAR GOES BADLY — Written while it is easy

The first week of January.



Nobody plans this week, and it decides the year
Renewals fall due, prices go up quietly, and the diary is empty enough to actually do something about it. An hour spent here in the first week is worth more than any resolution on this list.

WHAT RENEWS, AND AT WHAT PRICE Insurance...

WHAT RENEWS NEW PRICE DONE

			☐
			☐
			☐
			☐
			☐
			☐
			☐

DUE IN THE FIRST QUARTER Tax, bills, forms

WHAT DUE ROUGHLY DONE

			☐
			☐
			☐
			☐
			☐

AN HOUR OF ADMIN, ONCE

- ☐ Birthdays into next year’s calendar, all of them
- ☐ Passports and licences — check the expiry dates
- ☐ The medicine cabinet, and anything out of date
- ☐ Photographs backed up somewhere that is not the phone
- ☐ Appointments booked while the diary is empty
- ☐ One drawer, emptied

BOOKED IN JANUARY BECAUSE IT IS CHEAP

- ☐
- ☐
- ☐
- ☐
- ☐

PUT AWAY, AND WHERE The decorations, and this kit

-
-
-
-

The first of January.



HOW THE NIGHT WENT Write it today

DO AGAIN NEXT YEAR

☐

☐

☐

☐

DO NOT DO AGAIN

☐

☐

☐

TODAY, AND NOTHING MORE

- ☐ Water, and something to eat that is not sweet
- ☐ Outside for twenty minutes, whatever the weather
- ☐ The glasses washed before the evening
- ☐ Whoever stayed, fed before they drive
- ☐ Nothing started today; the diary begins tomorrow

MESSAGES WORTH SENDING TODAY

ONE LINE FOR THE YEAR THAT HAS STARTED

Save your filled-in copy. Next December, page 5 opens with this year's twelve lines already in it, and the year does not vanish.